

Berkeley: *First Dialogue*, concluded.

January 15, 2004

The argument from variation: some perspective

- Basic assumption: we have a kind of *direct* and *infallible* knowledge of our own experiences that we don't seem have about anything else.
 - 'I know you *think* you are in pain, but are you sure you're not mistaken?'
 - Even when we're hallucinating, we're still in a position to know about our own experiences.
 - When Berkeley talks of 'immediate perception', he's talking about a relation that confers this sort of infallible knowledge.

- Some of Berkeley's claims

1. No-one is immediately aware in *this* sense of material objects, independent of all perceivers.
2. The senses only give us immediate awareness of *ideas* (sensations).
3. The characteristic qualities of these sensations (for example, the distinctive quality that your sensations typically have when you look at ripe tomatoes) are not *shared* by material objects.
4. These characteristic qualities and relations are qualities like *redness, triangularity,...*

- Reasons to worry about the fourth of these claims.
 - On the one hand, it seems very natural to say that when I'm having an afterimage I'm aware of something red and round, or of redness and roundness.
 - On the other hand, it seems natural to say that certain material objects, like tomatoes, could be red and round, even if they don't share any qualities with sensations.
 - Some philosophers have suggested that words like 'red' and 'round' are *ambiguous*, standing in one sense for qualities of sensations, and standing in another sense for qualities of material objects.
 - Or have proposed that we introduce a new word, like 'red'', to stand for the quality we're immediately aware of.

- Important to keep track of which of Berkeley's arguments depend on rejecting this sort of view.
 - My hunch: the most important ones don't.

‘Absolute extension’

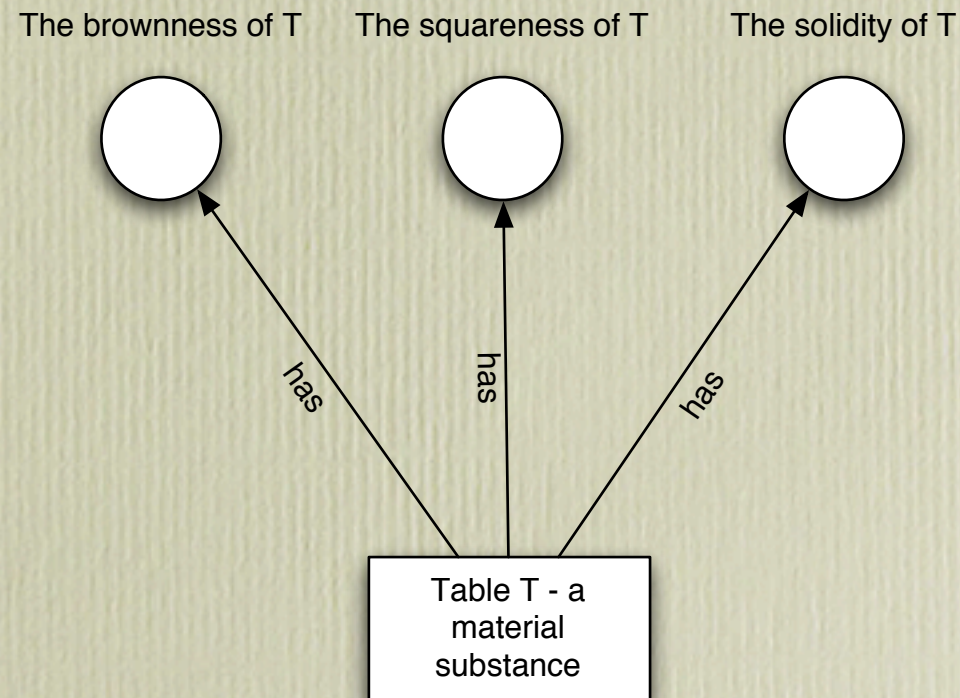
- On pp. 78-80, Berkeley considers the following view: material objects don’t share qualities like *great* and *small* with ideas, but they do share ‘absolute extension’ (i.e. *having some size*)
 - And presumably they also stand in relations like *bigger than*.
- His objection: *having some size* is an ‘abstraction’ from more specific qualities: so it can’t exist unless one of these do.

- We can't *conceive* of something as having size without conceiving it as having some particular size. There are no *abstract ideas*.
- In mathematics, all that happens is that we engage in reasoning for which certain details of our conceptions don't matter.

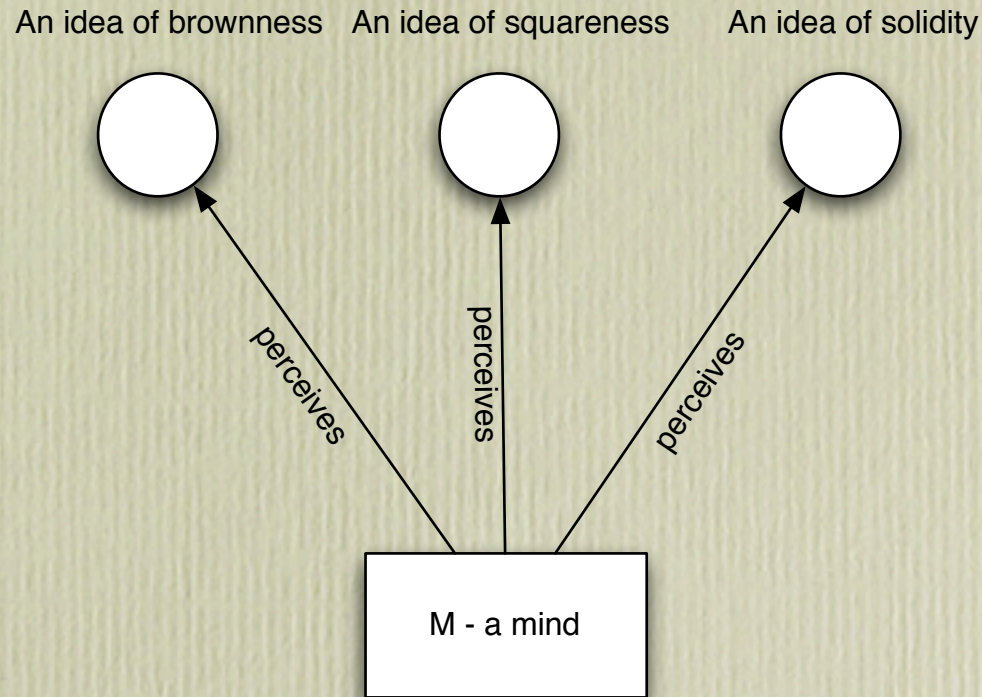
The rejection of material “substrata”

(pp. 83-85)

- A traditional picture Berkeley rejects as unintelligible:

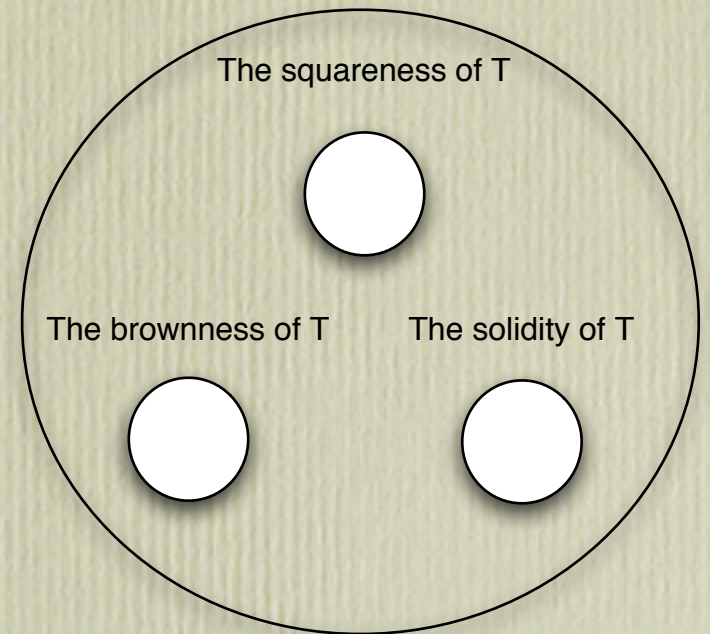


- By contrast, Berkeley thinks *this* is perfectly clear:



Question: don't minds have other properties — e.g. their capacities — that don't depend on what ideas they perceive?

- An alternative to the standard view suggested by Hylas:



T itself — the table — is just a 'bundle' of qualities

The “master argument”

(pp.85-86)

1. It is impossible to conceive of an unconceived-of object
2. Therefore, unconceived-of objects are inconceivable
3. Therefore, there are no unconceived-of objects
 - Notice that the argument would look equally good if we replace ‘unconceived-of’ with ‘unconceived of by me’... Something must be going wrong. What could it be?

- Suggestion: ‘x conceives of [imagines] an F’ seems to be ambiguous between the following two meanings: (i) ‘x conceives [imagines] that there is an F’ (ii) ‘there is an F, y, such that x conceives of y’.
- On reading (i), premise 1 is false; on reading (ii), step 3 doesn’t follow from step 2.